



» CHEQUERED FLAG

THE BULL SEES RED

In the 75th year of F1, Red Bull aims to **maintain its dominance** amidst internal turmoil, while Ferrari poses a growing challenge.

Dipak Ragav

dipak.ragav@thehindu.co.in

It is the 75th year of the FIA Formula One World Championship, and the sport faces a reckoning in its milestone year. Not long ago, F1 was booming, attracting new fans across the globe. The intense title battle in 2021 between Max Verstappen and Lewis Hamilton, which went down to the wire until the last lap of the last race, ignited a massive interest in the premier motorsports championship on the planet.

But two years have passed since the race in Abu Dhabi, and that season-long fight between the old guard and the upstart is now a distant memory.

The Verstappen-Red Bull Racing

combo has since steamrolled the opposition. If 2022 was a damp squib, with the Dutchman winning 15 out of 22 races, in 2023, he raised his game to another level, winning 19 out of 22 while his team won 21.

The current season is important for the sport's health, and a lot is riding on Red Bull's rivals stepping up to the plate and offering F1 fans something to look forward to.

However, right from pre-season testing, it was evident that Red Bull held a decent advantage over the pursuing pack. Unsurprisingly, Verstappen kick-started his title defence in style, posting easy wins in Bahrain and Saudi Arabia in the first two weekends of the year ahead of his teammate Sergio Perez.

The pecking order

After the first two rounds, it is

Trouble in paradise?: The Christian Horner (R) episode has fuelled rumours that Max Verstappen (L) could leave Red Bull and join Mercedes after Hamilton's departure in 2025. GETTY IMAGES

clear that Red Bull has a nearly half-second advantage per lap over its rivals, at least in Verstappen's hands. Despite the gap being slightly narrower in qualifying, Red Bull has no match for its speed on race day.

The Adrian Newey-designed cars have been ahead of the curve since the current ground-effect cars came into being in 2022. Red Bull has continued to build on its early mover advantage. The first two races also had different car demands, and the fact that Red Bull aced both quite easily shows that it has a car that will be competitive on most tracks on the calendar.

Behind Red Bull, Ferrari has started the season well and has emerged as the closest challenger to the reigning champion. In Bahrain, Carlos Sainz, who is in his last season